

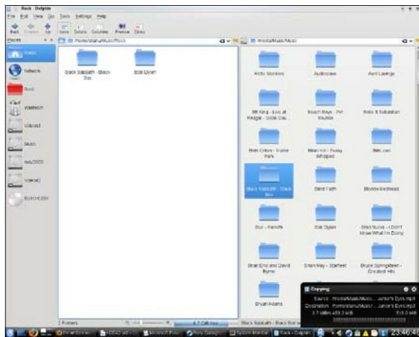


Figure 8: Split view in Dolphin file manager

these effects disabled as I find them distracting. I don't mind playing around with them when I need to kill time, or show off in front of those Winduhs users. And for that purpose, I'd rather prefer a native window manager to take care of the effects rather than using a third-party tool, which most of the time asks me to log out and log back in to activate/disable the effects. Although, I've got to admit, these effects work much better on Intel's graphics, rather than the proprietary drivers that ATI and Nvidia depend on—mostly due to bugs in the drivers.

A working man's place

Well, at the end of the day, with all these great features, you still need applications to survive. KDE 4.2, with its accompanying applications, doesn't disappoint here either. Whether it's a personal information manager, Internet apps, image and document viewers, media players, desktop administration tools, or other assorted utilities, it's got you more or less covered everywhere. And once the ambitious KOffice 2 goes stable (currently the CD includes the beta version), KDE4 could become an all-in-one desktop

powerhouse.

Although, we from the free software world have grown too used to OpenOffice.org for an office suite, KOffice 2 indeed offers a pretty useful alternative, which consumes a lot less memory compared to the former, besides introducing a pretty innovative user interface and set of features. The same is true if you compare Konqueror as a Web browser with Firefox. However, both KOffice and Konqueror have some catching up to do before they can pose a threat to the dominance of OpenOffice.org and Firefox, respectively.

In fact, now that KDE has got a default file manager called Dolphin, I hope the Konqueror developers concentrate more on its Web page rendering capabilities to make it compatible with the websites around the globe. One good option is to dump the KHTML engine for Webkit. Although Webkit is available as an optional rendering engine, the pages still appear ad hoc—which leads me to wonder what the issue might be, because I hear Google Chrome uses the same engine.

Anyway, for now, since we have OpenOffice.org and Firefox to take

care of our requirements, let's look at some of the other programs that help us in our day-to-day work.

Dolphin

The most important tool is obviously the file manager. This is what you essentially use to browse the gigabytes of data stored in your hard drive, which you can't do without. Dolphin concentrates on taking care of exactly this, unlike Konqueror in KDE3, which sort of posed as an all-in-one tool for multiple purposes.

The Dolphin interface is simple, with no frills at all. Okay, that information pane on the right looks slightly weird, you say? Well, it's there to display information about the file you select. But, if you want to get rid of it, simply hit F11 and it's gone. To tell you the truth, I don't like it either, and would rather have tool tips provide me the information when I hover my mouse over a file. That's doable too; you can configure all this from the *Configure Dolphin* option under the *Settings* menu.

A new addition in this release is the zoom slider at the bottom right corner of Dolphin—you can use it to increase the size of icons in the file manager. However, if you remember Dolphin from KDE 4.1, it used to display the free disk space in the same location, which is a nice way to keep an eye on your disk activities. What made it disappear this time? You got me there! But, again, you can enable it to appear beside the zoom slider from the *Configure Dolphin* option.

And here's two handy shortcuts for you, just in case you aren't aware of them already: if you don't like the breadcrumbs-based navigation bar, press Ctrl+L and you get the traditional input field to enter a location. If you want to filter a file from a directory listing hundreds of files, press Ctrl+F to get the filter input box at the bottom of the window. And if you want these features permanently available, visit *Configure Dolphin* again.

Dolphin does offer some